



Aashin Prasad

aashin.p@thehindu.co.in

In Indian football, the more things change, the more they remain the same.

Before the start of the Indian Super League season, the host broadcaster ran a promo quizzing — ‘Who is the next hero?’ of Indian football. Recently retired international, Sunil Chhetri, considered the face of the league for the previous decade, with yesteryear star Bhaichung Bhutia in tow, was taking consensus from leading names in Bollywood, Indian cricket and badminton on who among the next generation would take the mantle from Chhetri.

Eight months on, the find of the season has been Chhetri himself!

At 40, he matched his season-best tally of goals, outscoring any other Indian, which prompted an international retirement U-turn. While it's a testament to his drive and

No stopping him: In the 11 seasons, no Indian has won the Golden Boot. Sunil Chhetri leads the ISL scoring chart, but he has had the benefit of having played in 10 of the 11 campaigns.^{FSDL}

skill to keep delivering at the highest level, the inability to find his successor leaves a question mark over the ISL despite the 11-season run.

While the league has helped improve professional standards and technical expertise, it has not taken the sport in the country to the next level as was expected. The over-reliance on foreigners in key positions both on and off the field has yielded mixed results.

In the 11 seasons, no Indian has won the Golden Boot. Chhetri leads the ISL scoring chart, but he has had the benefit of having played in 10 of the 11 campaigns.

The four-foreigner rule in the playing XI isn't helping unearth the next Chhetri or Bhutia. Goals win

matches and teams over the years have imported players to carry out that task. During the ISL play-offs, Bengaluru played an all-Indian backline, which allowed it to stack its six available midfield and attacking positions with four overseas players.

Mohun Bagan's Manvir Singh (left, below), who can play multiple positions in the forward line, is a case study on having to fulfil two different roles for club and country due to the foreigner rule in the league.

In his five seasons at Bagan, he has had to make way to the right wing position for overseas players in the striker and centre-forward positions. Of his last 111 appearances in the league, Manvir has played as a centre-forward just nine times. But for the Indian team, during the same period, he has featured more times as a centre-forward (13) than as a right winger (9).

At the home of the ISL double champion Mohun Bagan, it's also a

Hard talk: While the ISL has undoubtedly raised the ceiling among the Indian players, there have also been accusations of complacency, most notably raised the national team coach, Manolo Marquez.^{ISL}

